

WELCOME TO THE DISC WORLD

A quick primer for players new to Terry Pratchett's world

TONE: dry, sarcastic, full of puns. Common sense is rare, so be polite to anyone carrying an axe, and never ask what's in the sausage.

THE DISC

A flat world, balanced on the backs of **four elephants**, who stand on the shell of a giant turtle (**Great A'Tuin**) swimming through space. Everyone here thinks this is perfectly normal. It's fantasy, but with the clichés poked until they squeak.

- **Narrative Causality:** stories *want* to happen. One-in-a-million chances come up nine times out of ten, and the funnier or more dramatic option usually wins. Lean in.
- **Magic is real and can do anything, but should it?** If it results in something interesting it will probably cooperate, but never without some sort of mishap. Clever wizards quickly learn to use it only in times of need.
- **Directions:** there's no north or south. Travel is **hubwards** (toward the Disc's centre), **rimwards** (toward the edge), **turnwise** (with the Disc's spin) or **widdershins** (against it).
- **Belief is power.** Gods, ideas and monsters exist because enough people believe in them.

ANKH-MORPORK

The biggest, smelliest, most cosmopolitan city on the Disc, and the home of nearly everyone you'll play. Sits on the **River Ankh**, so polluted it's crunchy, and you can almost walk across. Every species lives here, and gets along because everyone is equally mistrusted.

- **Lord Vetinari, the Patrician**, rules the city: a thin, calm, terrifying tyrant who is both feared *and* respected, and who somehow keeps the whole mess running. You do not want him to take an interest in you.
- **The Guilds run everything.** Rather than fight crime, the city regulates it:
 - **Thieves:** licensed, with a yearly quota. Pay your dues and you get a receipt, and nobody else will rob you.
 - **Assassins:** gentlemen and ladies of taste, with a dress code and rules of engagement. Murder is a profession like any other.
 - **Beggars:** licensed pitches and a strict pecking order. Don't even *think* of poaching a corner.
 - **Fools:** clowns and jesters, professionally trained. Funnier than they look, and pies are serious business.
 - **Seamstresses:** not to be confused with "needlewomen" (those who actually mend textiles). The guild instead provides ladies of negotiable affection.
- **The City Watch** is run by **Commander Vimes** and recruits from every species in the city. The members range from sharp to sleepy, and they're underfunded and rarely taken seriously (except by the criminals).
- **Unseen University** is where the wizards live, eat enormous meals, and are carefully ignored. The Librarian is an orangutan.

YOU ARE A DWARF



Art by Paul Kidby, originally featured in *The Art of Discworld* (2004)

- **What you are:** short, sturdy, bearded. Yes, **all** dwarfs have beards, women included, and traditionally you can't tell the difference (nor are you meant to). You wear leather, chainmail, a woolly vest, and **always carry an axe**.
- **Gender:** traditional dwarfs say "he" for everybody; gender matters less than metallurgy. There are no female pronouns in Dwarvish. Newer "modern" dwarfs (skirts, makeup) are starting to present how they like. Traditional dwarves still disapprove, but in Ankh-Morpork you're protected by city law.
- **Culture:** serious, dutiful, literate and honest. Mining and metalwork are your passions, and you'll sing about gold in a tavern, though you prefer iron for real work. Your axe is a pickaxe on one side and a war axe on the other. Rat is your main meat (rat pie, rat on a stick), usually smothered in sauce to hide the taste.
- **Dwarf Bread:** rock-hard, never goes stale, and occasionally used as a weapon. Proper dwarf bread is not just baked, it's forged.
- **Politics:** trolls and dwarfs have hated each other for ages. In the city it's a rocky truce.
- **Stereotypes:** gruff, dutiful and pedantic. Takes statements literally; for example, if told to "pull it together", they might look around to see what is missing.
- **Names:** Gimlet, Cheery, Bashful, Glod, Rocksmacker, Ironfoundersson, Littlebottom.